Icons - Design Guidelines

Created by Tony Wang, last modified by Hillary Purssey on 14 Jan 2021

Best Practices

Function over Form
Literal symbols are easier to understand than abstract symbols. Go for the most basic idea or concept instead of a metaphorical one. Whenever possible, use universally recognised icons. Users will be familiar with the symbol allowing them to quickly take actions or understand information with confidence.

Detail and Complexity
Use the simplest form to communicate an icon. Unnecessary detail can overcomplicate an icon making it more difficult to read at a small scale. Use simple characteristic cues to drive connections between real world objects.

Limit Icon Variations
Use a single icon to represent variations of the same concept. Don't create a custom icon for similar concepts—it bloats the icon library and makes it difficult for users to create strong connections around a concept.

Find the Neutral Ground
Wherever possible use gender neutral characters or culturally agnostic symbols unless specifically representing a certain group or peoples. Avoid stereotypical representations (this is more relevant for illustrations however the same thinking applies to icons).

Quality is Key
Aim for quality over quantity. Fewer icons that have been carefully considered will allow for better user understanding. Icons must have smooth lines (no bumps or jagged edges) and be pixel perfect. An icon that has been poorly constructed (i.e. does not follow the guidelines outlined below) will not be added to the Telstra Icon Suite.

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Building Icons

- Icons - Production Guidelines
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Drawing Icons

Tools

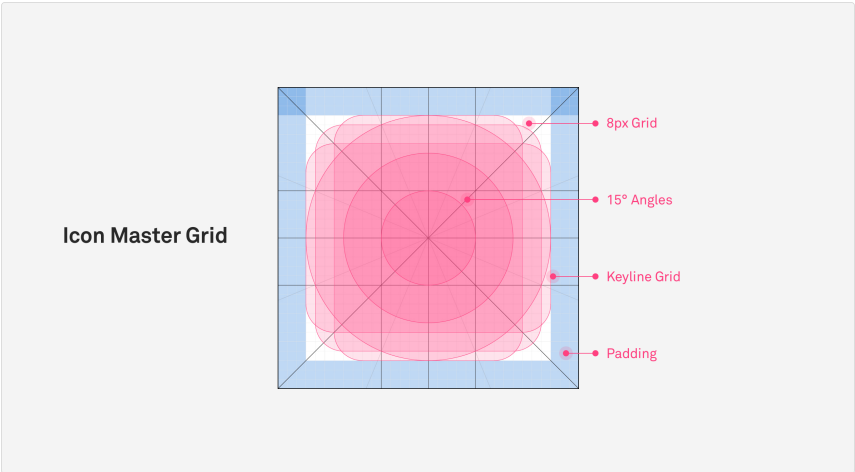
Telstra Icons are constructed using Adobe Illustrator. This tool is used as it is accessible across the business for designers working in both print and digital.
Do not build icons in sketch or any other tool.

A Master Grid template is available and should be used to build an icon.
Refer to the Production Guidelines to draw an icon.

Master Grid

The icon grid establishes clear rules for the consistent, but flexible, positioning of graphic elements.

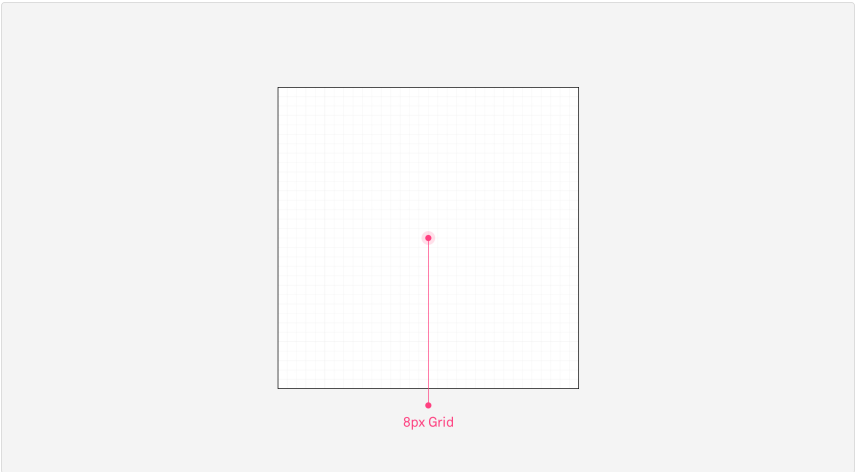
The master grid has been constructed from the elements listed below.



8px base grid

Telstra icons are drawn on a pixel-based grid of 32x32px and scaled up or down to different sizes. Use the grid as base guidelines and ensure 'snap to grid' is set in Illustrator. This is to ensure that are icons can be pixel perfect according to our base grid.
Icons must be aligned to the grid and built at the whole pixel to ensure clarity across digital products. Strokes with decimals or that are not aligned to the grid may appear blurry or have poor render quality that can hinder legibility and readability.

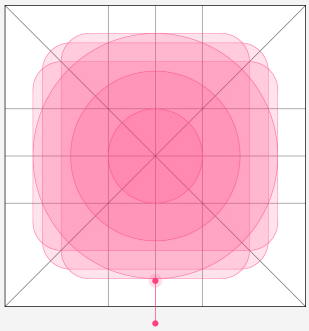
**Please note - you may need to make optical / fine-tuning adjustments (more on this below)*

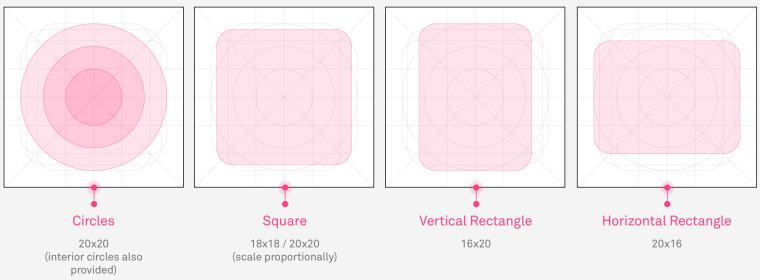


Keyline shapes

(also known as Contour Lines)

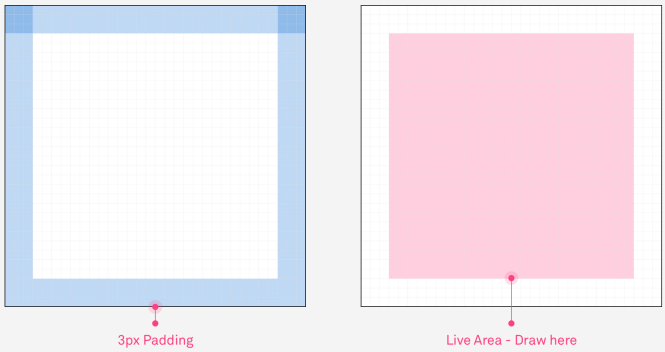
Keylines are the core shapes to be used as guidelines. By aligning icons to these basic shapes all icons will have clearly defined relationships and similarly consistent visual proportions for a visually stable suite.





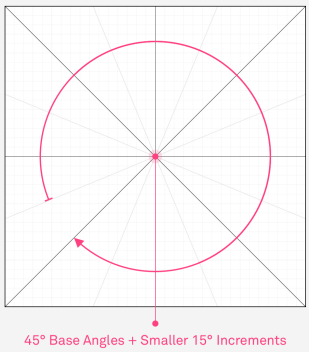
Live Area and Padding

The Master grid contains 3px padding for Telstra icons. This ensure icons are scaled proportionally with consistent white space when exported.
Always draw icons within the Live Area leaving the padding as white space.



Angles

Telstra icons use 45° angles as a base. 15° angles can also be used for additional shapes when required.
Consistent angles ensure visual harmony across the suite.

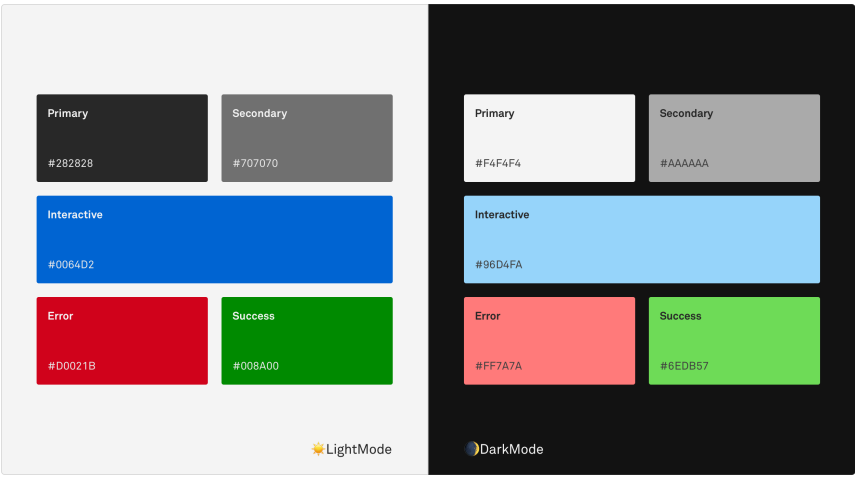


Icon Design Guidelines

Colour (Digital)

Icons are always a solid, monochromatic colour and need to pass the same colour contrast ratio as typography (4.5:1). The colour of the icon should reflect the importance of the icon's action which should always be to help guide a user.

Icons should be built and exported Black.
Icons should be coloured using Icon Colour Aliases
Refer to Icons Documentation for how colour should be applied to icons.



Size

For **digital**, icons have been designed to work best in two sizes: 24px and 32px. Please use icons at their originally produced size. These are provided in PDF, SVG and Adobe Illustrator files.

For **print**, icons can be scaled up to any size. Make sure to use a vector format to preserve quality and any size.

Consider the larger an icon is, the thicker the line will be. Icons are recommended to be used small in proportion to the rest of the content.

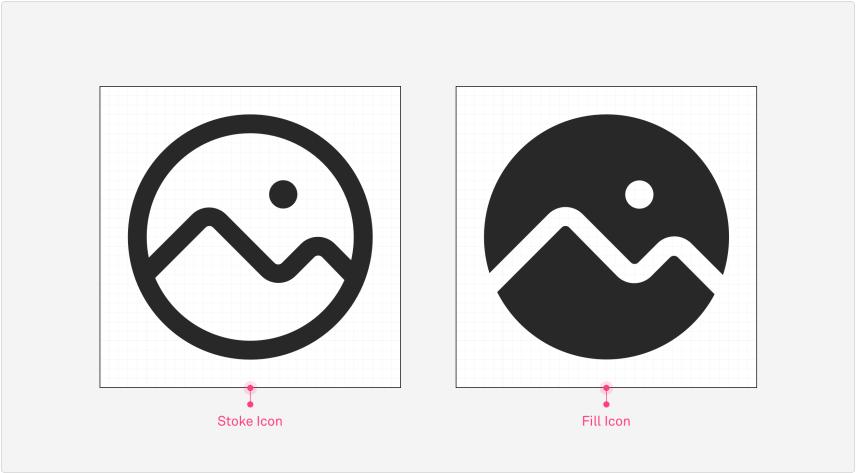
Size	Stroke Width	Padding	Live Area	Corner Radius	Type Size/s
24	Scaled down from 32				16
32	2px*	3px	26px	2px, 4px or 6px	20 and 24

*Fill icons like iconWarning, iconError etc use a 3px stroke for internal elements -this is to visually offset internal elements weighting to ensure content within doesn't isn't lost in the fill colour.

Stroke and Fill

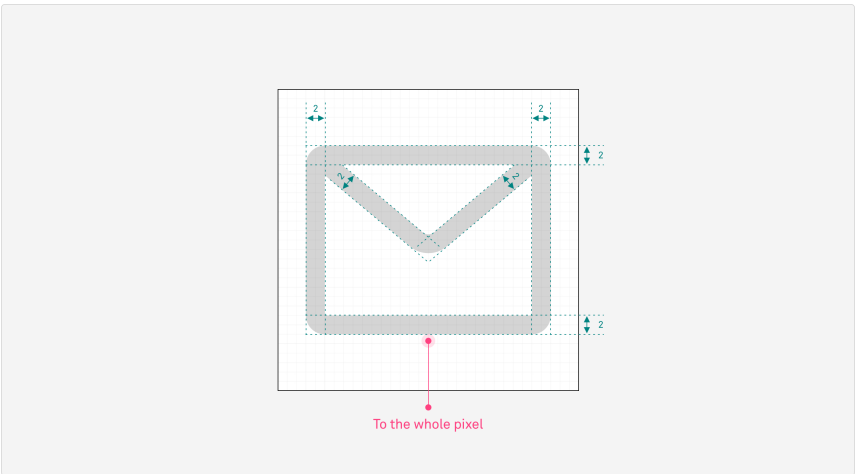
Telstra Icons are stroke style.
Icons must have a consistent stroke weight to the whole pixel.
Telstra Icons have a 2px stroke.
Both the stroke and counter (interior) stroke must be 2px (unless optical adjustments required)

Telstra uses fill styles only in the instances listed below.



One icon should not look heavier or lighter than other icons of the same size. Nor should there be different weights within one icon. Maintain the same visual weight by using a 2px stroke for all icons.

Please note: There are a few exceptions to this rule which occurs when the icon is complex or has a certain density of line. See 'interior elements' and 'optical adjustments'

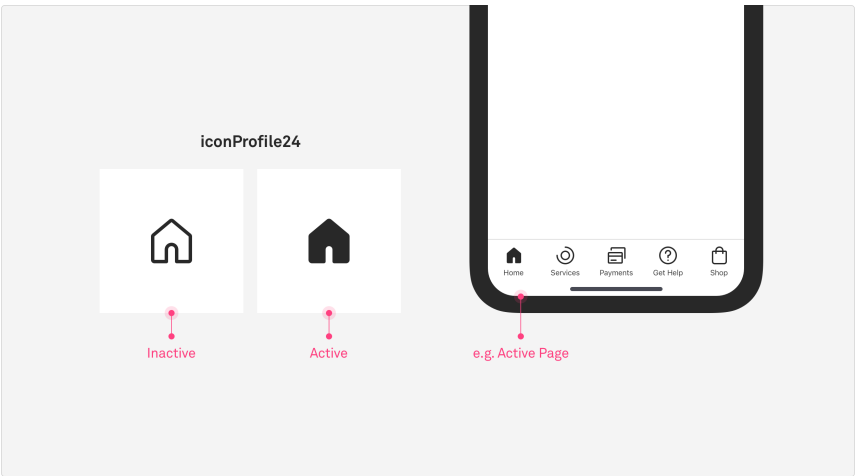


Stroke & Fills: Interactive

That is to show an icon is **'active'** or **'on'**

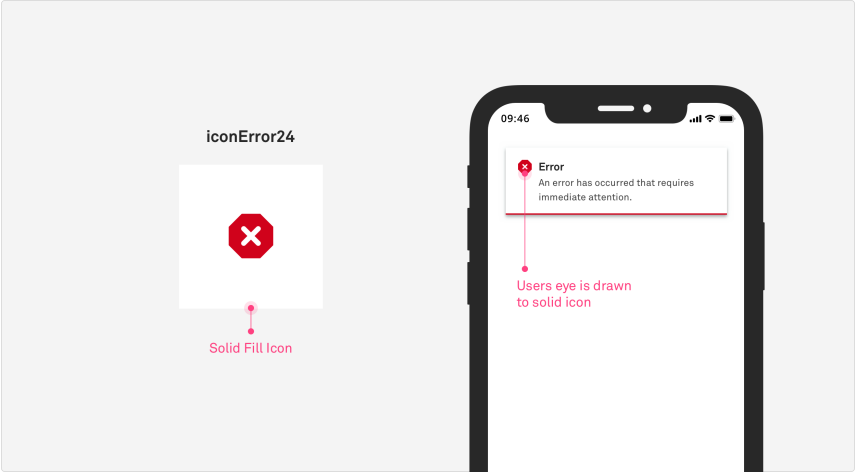
We use fill styles to provide appropriate affordance for users who might be visually impaired as we can not rely on colour contrast to indicate this important state change. All icons default or normal states are stroke style.

*Note - some icons like Search can not have a fill icon variant as the shape / meaning is lost. Instead a thicker line is recommended to indicate 'active'.



Stroke & Fills: Important

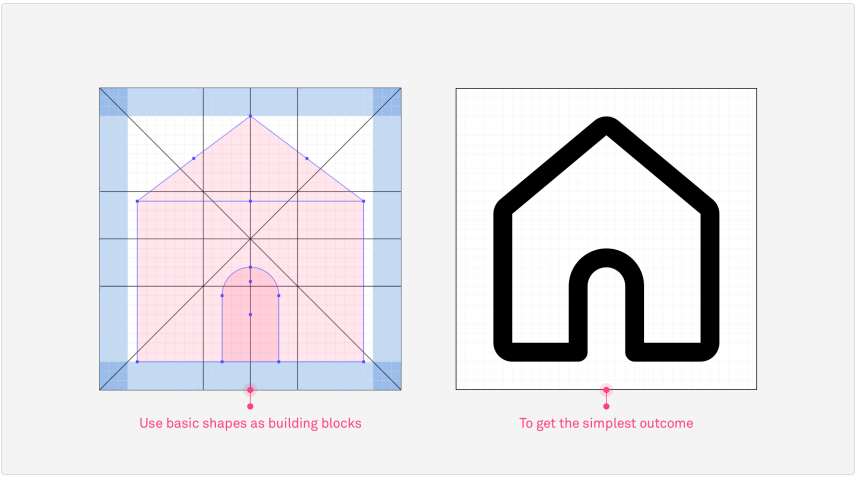
That is for status icons like Success, Error, Warning or Information
We use fill styles in this instance as fill icons have more visual weight when used sparingly. A fill icon will draw the users eye to status based icons that need immediate attention.



Shape: Simplest Form

When building icons - start with basic shapes as the building blocks. For example, a house icon can be built using a square and a triangle. Consider the icon being created and break it down to its simplest shapes.

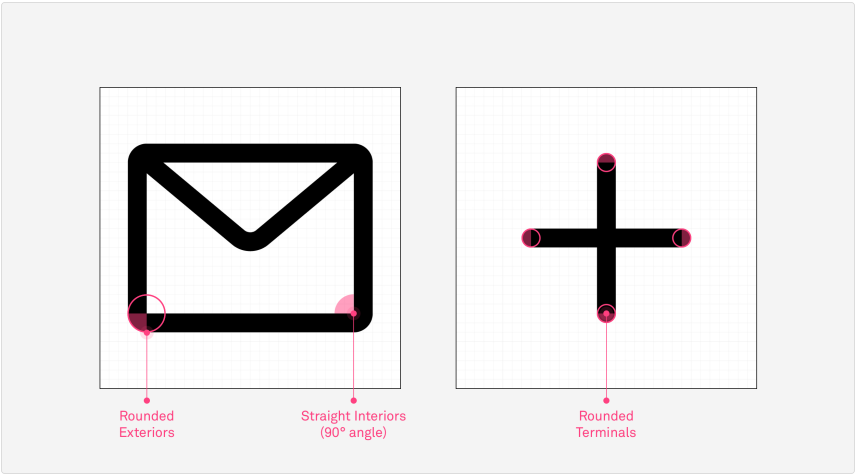
Doing this ensures icons are constructed at their simplest form as well as control smooth curves and defined lines.

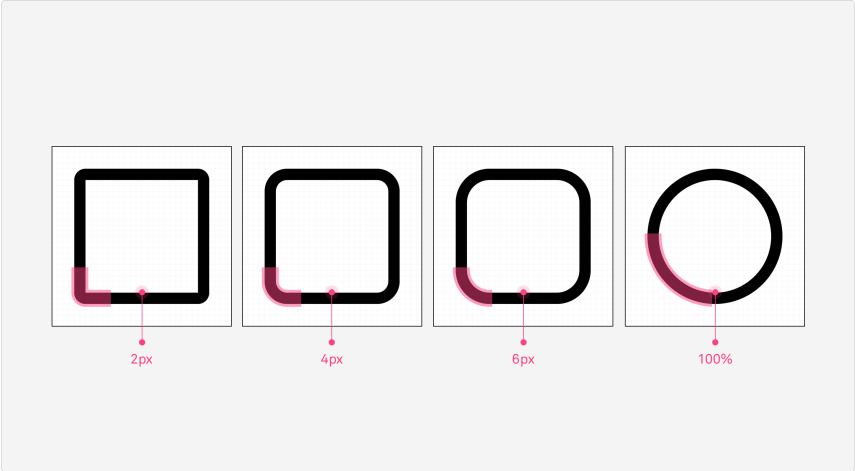


Shape: Corners & Terminals

Exterior corners should be slightly rounded. Interior corners should be square, not rounded. This is achievable by drawing icons with stroke lines aligned inside.

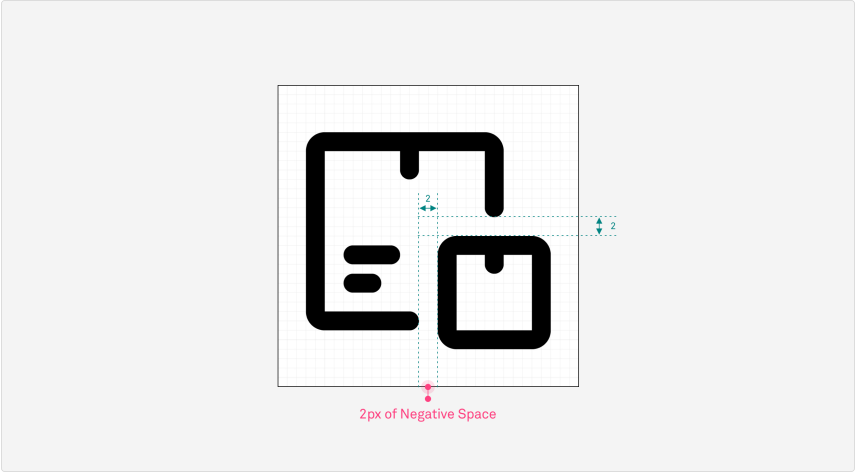
Telstra icons have fully rounded terminals.





Overlapping Elements

If an icon is requires more than 1 object to express a concept - it is recommend a small line break is used to represent visual depth (shown in example below).
A 2px break is ideal to provide appropriate white space to communicate layered objects.



Perspective & Optical Adjustments

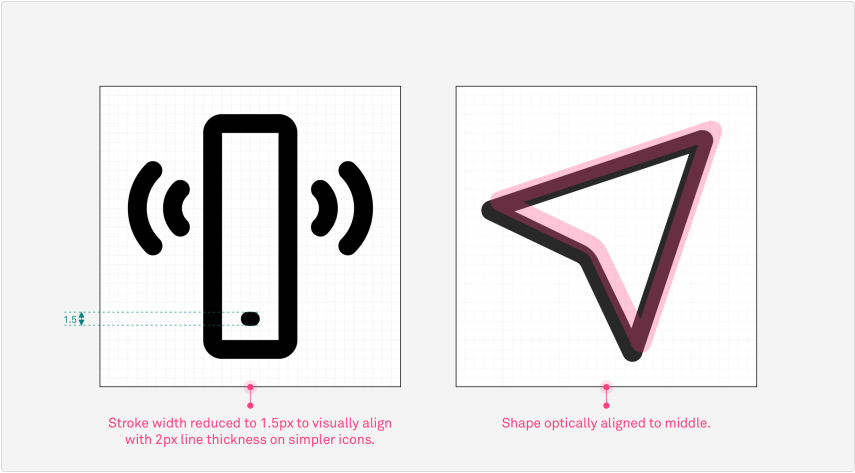
Be sure to avoid dimensional representations. Use more objective vantage points that are straight-on, or profile views.

Optical adjustments will sometimes need to be required for the following reasons:

- An icon symbol has **unavoidable** complex shapes or lines. This causes an icon to appear / feel more visually dense or heavier. It is recommended to use a thinner (1.5px stroke) in these instances.
- An icon appears misaligned when mechanically aligned. This can be seen for play button icons or similarly odd shaped icons - instead it is recommended you turn off 'snap to grid' and visually align icons to appear optically centred.

Interior elements may use a 1.5px stroke weight to minimise internal density however avoid this wherever possible.

⚠️ These icons MUST be approved by the VD Chapter and a representative from Digital Systems before it can be added to the Icon Suite.



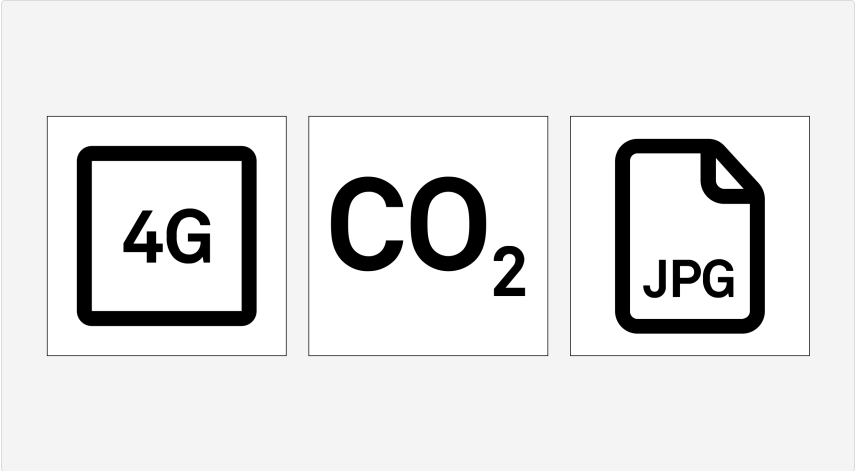
Text in Icons

Text are not recommended in icons. Due to the small scale text is very difficult to read and mostly useless for providing any user understanding.

That being said, if an icon requires text a max of 3 letterforms may be used. Some examples of instances where this is appropriate has been provided. Use Telstra Akkurat font.

This is an accessibility consideration that must be adhered to.

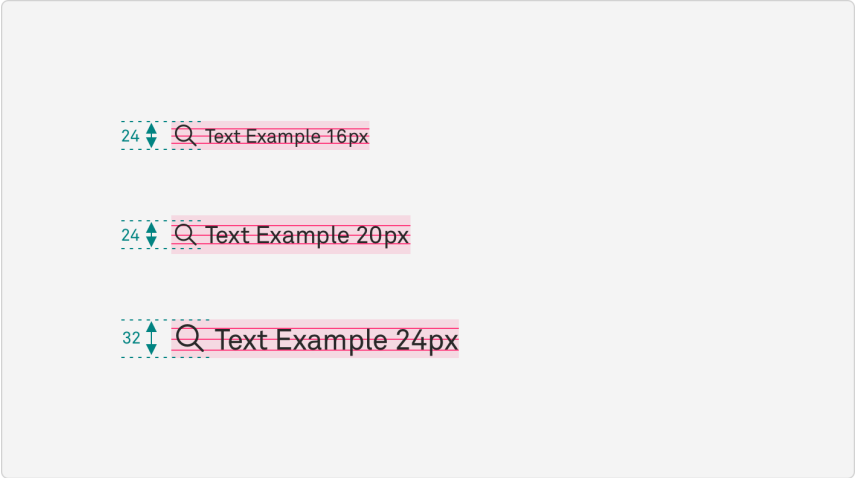
Please note: Large letterforms should follow same styling as icon (i.e. round terminals)



Text Alignment

Pair 24px icons with Text 16 and Text 20
Pair 32px icons with Text 24 and above
Middle align icons and text - do not align to the baseline.
It is recommended you stress test icons by sense checking alignment and scale with the corresponding text size.

Ensure icons are **optically aligned** to the centre of the grid. An example of an icon that will need to be positioned off-centre to appear centre is a play icon - an icon like this will need to be visually offset to appear centre aligned.



No labels